
Economics Is Everywhere

A 20-minute introduction for students and parents

UNBC Economics

What economics is, why it matters, and where it can take you

Student outreach presentation

1. What is economics?

Choices, scarcity, trade-offs, and incentives.

2. Why does it matter?

Grocery bills, housing, jobs, inflation, climate, and policy.

3. What do economists study?

From behavioural economics to finance and sustainability.

4. Why study economics?

Skills, flexibility, and career pathways.

Big idea

Economics is not just about money. It is a way of understanding how the world works.

What is economics?

The simplest definition

Economics in plain language

Economics is the study of how people, businesses, and governments make choices when resources are limited.

- We all face scarcity: limited time, money, energy, and opportunities.
- Because resources are limited, every choice has a trade-off.
- Economics helps us think clearly about those trade-offs.

Student example

Sleep
Good grades
Part-time job
Friends
Relaxation

Only 24 hours

That is economics.

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Economics is already part of everyday life

You are already doing economics

At home

- Grocery budgets
- Saving vs. spending
- Rent, mortgage, and bills
- Family trade-offs

At school

- Choosing courses
- Managing time
- Working while studying
- Planning the future

In society

- Inflation and wages
- Housing affordability
- Taxes and public services
- Climate policy

Economics is what you are already doing - even if you never call it economics.

Four real life examples

Economics shows up in ordinary decisions

Coffee shop line

High demand + limited supply = waiting time.

Concert tickets

Scarce seats + huge demand = resale prices jump.

Grocery shopping

Families switch products when prices rise.

Opportunity cost

The real cost of a choice is the value of the next best alternative you give up.

Choosing a degree

The question is not only *What do I like?* but also *What opportunities does it open?*

If you spend three hours scrolling instead of studying, economics politely asks: what did that really cost?

The big questions economics helps explain

From headlines to real life

Inflation

Why do
prices rise?

Unemployment

Why are jobs
hard to find?

Housing

Why is housing
expensive?

Climate

How should
we respond?

A core economist habit

Do not stop at the first effect. Ask: **what happens next?**

- Policies can help, but they can also create side effects and unintended consequences.
- Economics trains us to look at the second and third round effects too.

Economics is about people, not just numbers

Human stories sit behind the statistics

- Families deciding how to use limited income
- Students choosing what to study and where to work
- Workers searching for stable jobs and better wages
- Governments deciding how to spend limited budgets
- Communities trying to improve quality of life

Important point

Good economics is deeply human. It studies well-being, fairness, incentives, and the consequences of choices.

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What if humans are not perfect decision-makers?

- Traditional economics often starts with rational decision-makers.
- Behavioural economics studies how people **actually** behave.
- It looks at procrastination, habits, overconfidence, peer effects, and self-control problems.
- It helps explain why people delay saving, overspend, or stick with defaults.

Everyday version

“Starting tomorrow, I will save more, exercise more, and stop buying things online.”

Funny truth

Humans are not robots. Sometimes we are not even very good spreadsheets.

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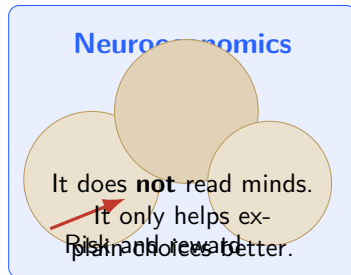
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What it studies

Neuroeconomics examines what happens in the brain when people make choices involving risk, reward, trust, impulse, and emotion.

- Why do people take risks?
- Why does immediate reward often beat long-term benefit?
- How do emotions affect financial decisions?



Other fascinating fields in economics

Economics is broad, modern, and interdisciplinary

Labour economics

Jobs, wages, skills, unemployment.

Environmental economics

Climate, pollution, sustainability.

Health economics

Healthcare costs, access, and policy.

Development economics

Poverty, education, growth, and living standards.

Financial economics

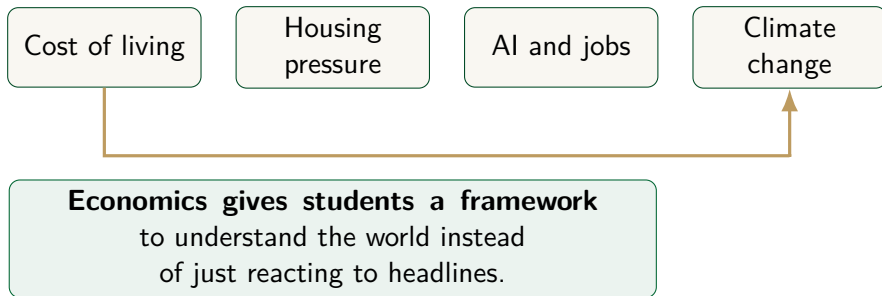
Banking, investing, markets, and risk.

Public economics

Taxes, spending, and government policy.

Why economics matters now more than ever

A changing world needs economic thinking



What skills does economics build?

Skills for university, work, and life

Analytical skills

- Critical thinking
- Problem solving
- Data interpretation
- Decision-making under uncertainty

Transferable skills

- Clear writing and communication
- Understanding incentives
- Spotting unintended consequences
- Connecting evidence to policy

These are not only economist skills. They are career skills and life skills.

Why students should consider economics

Practical, flexible, and career-relevant

- Economics is practical and relevant to everyday life.
- It combines numbers, ideas, and real-world problems.
- It works well on its own or with business, political science, data science, and environmental studies.
- It opens doors to many careers.

Common pathways

- Government and public policy
- Banking and finance
- Business and consulting
- Research and analytics
- Law, education, and graduate study

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A message for students and parents

Why economics is worth serious consideration

For students

If you are curious about how the world works and enjoy asking “why,” economics is worth exploring.

For parents

Economics develops adaptable, analytical, employable graduates with skills valued across many sectors.

A light joke

After one economics course, students may finally understand why “we cannot buy everything” is not just parenting. It is scarcity.

Bottom line

Economics helps people make better choices, ask better questions, and understand the world more clearly.

**Economics is not just a subject.
It is a way of understanding the world.**

Thank you

Questions?